

Content Authoring Guidelines — Inkglass Odyssey

Design document. Read before authoring NPCs, items, abilities, lore, recipes, or world events in the Library Workshop or Admin Workshop.

Cross-references: docs/schemas_reference.md (all schema definitions), docs/economy_balance.md (pricing/balance tables), docs/combat_system.md (HP/damage reference values).

NPC Authoring Quality Priorities

1. Voice examples first

Few-shot exchanges teach the LLM how to sound like this character more than any prose description. Write voice examples before the personality description. The personality summary should describe what you already demonstrated.

Each example can be tagged with a context (casual, tense, hostile, transactional) to naturally cover different emotional registers. Admin Workshop requires minimum five. DM Workshop requires minimum two.

2. Knowledge boundaries must be tight

Use separate “knows about” and “does not know about” lists. Broad boundaries (“knows about politics, history, magic”) cause NPCs to confidently improvise about topics without authored lore. Specific exclusions (“Does not know: court politics, magical theory, events outside this region”) prevent this.

The Workshop warns when the “knows” list exceeds 8–10 entries.

3. Manipulation resistance must match the archetype

A merchant deflects with confusion: “I... sell herbs? I don’t understand what you’re asking me to ignore.” A guard deflects with suspicion: “That’s a strange thing to say. Move along.” A scholar deflects with pedantic redirection. Generic refusals are useless.

4. Secrets must have reveal conditions

Every secret entry specifies: relationship score threshold, quest flag, check type and DC, or “never” (dramatic irony only). Secrets without conditions either leak immediately or never surface — both are bad. Tag each as information (something the NPC knows) or identity

(something about the NPC that others might discover).

5. Decomposed narrative fields

The NPC personality schema decomposes character into distinct fields rather than a single personality_summary blob:

- **personality_background** — core personality, history, formative experiences. Write as actionable traits: "Distrusts authority figures and will subtly test whether the player defers to power" is better than "grew up in a village."
- **goals** — immediate (scene-level) and long_term (arc-level). An NPC without goals is furniture.
- **weaknesses_fears** — can tie to mechanical hooks (check modifiers when weakness is triggered).
- **communication_style** — cadence, vocabulary, verbal habits. Concrete examples beat abstract labels: "Uses maritime metaphors constantly" not "talks like a sailor."
- **power_narrative** — abilities described narratively for the LLM, separate from the mechanical stat block.
- **relationships** — typed references to other NPCs with dynamic descriptions.

6. Mechanical stat block is separate

The relay uses the stat block (ability scores, AC, HP, resistances). The LLM uses the narrative fields. These serve different systems. The stat block is never passed to the LLM. The Workshop computes HP automatically from level + hit_die + CON score.

7. Animation profiles should be pre-filled

The Workshop pre-fills defaults based on role: shopkeepers get relaxed/direct, guards get formal/scanning. Adjust if the character carries themselves differently. Minimum three entries in the emotional_state_to_animation map.

8. Shop and transport NPCs

Shop NPC inventory should use the Workshop's item picker, not manual ID entry. The "shop economics" panel shows: total inventory value, expected sales per session, variety assessment. A shop with only common items bores Established players.

Transport NPCs route definitions should use region pickers.

Item and Ability Authoring

Description prose and mechanical stats must align. The Workshop displays them side by side. A legendary weapon described blandly will feel disappointing. A common tool described as extraordinary will feel mechanically underwhelming.

Balance guidance is displayed live: expected damage per hit vs. HP at the relevant level band, healing amounts vs. damage intake rates, price vs. session earning rates. Warnings fire when values are out of range but do not block saves.

Ability healing should restore 1.5–2x consumable amounts at the same tier to justify the resource cost.

Ability level requirements should display the progression band context. Setting minimum level to 6 shows “Available at Established tier.” Setting it to 16 shows “Available at Legendary tier — very few players reach this.”

Resource costs use the world’s terminology. In murim: Qi points. In inkglass_dark: spell slots. The form adapts to the selected world.

Lore Entry (world_info.json) Quality

Each RAG chunk must be **self-contained** — readable without any other chunk. “See above” or cross-references to other entries are useless as retrieved context.

Target length: 100–400 words. Under 100: insufficient context for NPC use. Over 400: crowds other relevant chunks out of the token budget. The Workshop shows a word count with colour indicator.

Keywords must be concrete nouns and proper names: “Iron Accord,” “Merchant Guild,” “Dockside Riots.” Generic keywords (“history,” “politics,” “trade”) cause over-retrieval. The Workshop warns when keywords are too broad.

Confidence rating: each chunk carries canonical, probable, or rumor — affects how definitively NPCs reference this information.

Worldbible Files (overview.md, factions.md, etc.)

These are long-form prose documents for human readers, separate from RAG chunks. Split-pane editor with live preview.

Key guidance: each heading should correspond to something a player might ask about. If a player says “tell me about the Merchant Guild,” there should be a heading for it. If there isn’t, either add one or ensure a lore chunk covers it.

Recipe Authoring

Input material costs must total less than the output item's value (target: 30–50% profit margin). The Workshop auto-calculates and flags imbalanced recipes.

Discovery method distribution matters: if every recipe is “taught,” no exploration incentive. If every recipe is “experimentation,” no NPC interaction incentive. The Workshop shows the world-level distribution.

World Event Authoring

Foreshadowing signals should be authored for every major event. NPCs mentioning rumours, environmental changes, ambient mood shifts before an event fires make the world feel alive. Events without foreshadowing appear from nowhere.

Variant outcomes based on player state are strongly encouraged for major events. A plot beat that fires identically regardless of choices undermines agency.

narrator_prompt_addendum should be written for events that change the world's mood — injected into the scene narrator's context when the event fires or is imminent.